Community Host and Facilitator Guide

Chico Campout for Compassion 2026 | November 14, 2026

One Night. Many Locations. One Community.

Back to the Campout event

You don’t have to camp out to participate! Host or join a discussion, show a video, invite a speaker, help with basic-needs giving, or share the event. Overnight camping is optional.

Why We’re Here ... A Conversation, Not an Argument

Our approach may appear left-leaning, but this event isn’t about left or right. We welcome research, countering material, and different perspectives. We aren’t here to tell anyone what to think or how it should be done ... only to start conversations.

Read our full statement of purpose Download PDF

Recommended Resources ... Not Required

Our educational materials reflect a "shelter first" and lowest-barrier approach to addressing homelessness. They are recommended resources, not required material. If your group chooses not to use them, your participation is still encouraged.

Awareness doesn’t take sides ... all voices and perspectives are encouraged. However, Campout for Compassion will not provide or recommend "treatment first" materials.

Chico Campout for Compassion 2026 Saturday, November 14, 2026

COMMUNITY HOST & FACILITATOR GUIDE

Saturday, November 14, 2026 One night. Many locations. One community.

A citywide invitation to see the people, learn the facts, change the narrative, and recognize the dignity of our neighbors experiencing homelessness.

For churches, youth groups, schools, service clubs, neighborhood groups, families, and individuals

This is an independent Chico awareness initiative ... not a fundraising campaign. Optional food, basic-needs supplies, or gifts go directly to existing local programs.

Organizer contact: Scotty Franzyshen | scotty@sfranzyshen.org

NEW - CORE EDUCATIONAL PROGRAM ... CHANGE THE NARRATIVE

Primary goal: Help Chico residents see the people behind homelessness, challenge assumptions with reliable evidence, and have honest conversations. Iain De Jong’s shared-values video is now an optional deeper resource, not the central program. You do not have to camp out, host a gathering, or agree with a policy to participate.

Our foundation: Invisible People’s 2025 Effective Homelessness Advocacy Messaging Toolkit explains that the way people understand homelessness shapes the responses they support. We use its communication lessons ... not its audience survey as if it were a Chico housing count.

Recommended 60-minute group activity:

* Welcome and respectful ground rules (5 minutes).

* SEE ... watch one vetted Invisible People firsthand interview or invite a local speaker (10 minutes).

* LEARN ... discuss three assumptions using the myths, facts, and realities guide (15 minutes).

* CHICO ... explore locally sourced housing and shelter questions. Mark anything unverified as a question, not a fact (10 minutes).

* DISCUSS ... what surprised you, what remains uncertain, and how you would treat a neighbor (15 minutes).

* REFLECT ... one thing learned, one assumption reconsidered (5 minutes).

Short home option ... 15 - 20 minutes: Share one first-person interview or reading, ask which assumption it challenges, check one reliable source, and have a short conversation. A congregation may simply share the invitation and these resources; no church-hosted campout is necessary.

Facts and fairness: distinguish firsthand testimony, research-based generalizations, and verified Chico-specific data. Don't diagnose people, equate shelter beds with permanent homes, or say an encampment removal ended someone's homelessness. Never ask someone to perform trauma for an audience.

Related resources: Firsthand video guide ; Activities for all ages ; Optional shared-values learning .

OPTIONAL 10-MINUTE DISCUSSION ... SURVIVAL PRIORITIES

The Rule of Threes doesn't settle housing policy, but it does provide a clear, scientifically grounded starting point for discussing basic human needs.

Explain the commonly taught survival priorities: about 3 minutes without breathable air, 3 hours without protection from extreme exposure, 3 days without drinking water, and 3 weeks without food. These figures are approximate memory aids, not exact medical timelines . Wilderness educators use them to prioritize threats. CDC guidance independently documents the serious dangers of cold and heat exposure.

Ask participants: (1) Why does survival teaching prioritize exposure and shelter before food? (2) What is the difference between an emergency shelter for tonight and stable housing? (3) What if a particular shelter is unsafe, inaccessible, or does not meet a person's needs?

Do not ask people to sleep outdoors without protection or simulate dangerous exposure. This is a discussion exercise, not a survival challenge. Read the full educational explanation and source links .

01 - PURPOSE

Start here: What is Campout for Compassion? Chico Campout for Compassion invites community groups to host their own safe, supervised gathering on the same night. Participants learn about homelessness, hear from people who have experienced it, discuss local barriers, and reflect on what it means to have a reliable home.

The event is designed to bring people together across religious, political, and neighborhood differences. A host can run a two-hour evening program or an approved overnight campout.

What this event is - An awareness and listening event with age-appropriate learning activities.

- Many independent host locations; each host is responsible for its own permissions and safety.

- An opportunity for people with lived experience to share what they choose to share.

- An optional direct-to-provider food or basic-needs drive.

What this event is not - Not an attempt to reproduce the experience of homelessness.

- Not a central fundraiser, new nonprofit, political rally, or overnight endurance challenge.

- Not a requirement to sleep outdoors; participation can be indoor or daytime.

- Not a competition for who can tolerate the most discomfort.

Our central message: We can choose to sleep outside for a night and return to our own beds the next day. Many neighbors do not have that choice.

One night cannot teach us what homelessness feels like. Listening to people who have lived it can help us understand more.

02 - HOST GUIDE

Host options and responsibilities Each group can participate according to its capacity. A complete overnight campout is not required.

OPTION A - Evening gathering

Two to three hours of speakers, discussion, age-based activities, and reflection.

Suitable for school groups, families with young children, or venues that cannot host overnight.

OPTION B - Overnight event

An evening program followed by supervised sleeping at a permitted location, plus a morning reflection.

All overnight arrangements remain the host organization’s responsibility.

OPTION C - Family participation

Family discussion, an age-appropriate activity, and optional outdoor sleeping at a permitted private home.

Children participate with their parent or guardian.

OPTION D - Community service partner

Help with first-person speakers, useful factual information, supply lists, or follow-up opportunities.

An organization can support education without hosting a campout.

Each host commits to - One named event coordinator and clear adult supervision.

- Use language that treats people experiencing homelessness as people, not labels.

- Provide reasonable accommodations and allow anyone to leave or participate indoors.

- Get property approval and any required permits before advertising an overnight venue.

- Collect no money on behalf of this citywide campaign.

Local autonomy: Hosts may adapt the program to their faith tradition or organization, as long as the event remains respectful, safe, and faithful to its awareness purpose.

03 - NON-NEGOTIABLE SAFEGUARDS

Keeping everyone safe and respected This page is a starting checklist, not a substitute for the host’s legal, insurance, fire-safety, accessibility, or child-protection obligations.

Physical safety - Confirm written property permission, applicable fire and event requirements, and insurance with the

venue.

- Use a site with toilets, drinking water, lighting, accessible routes, emergency vehicle access, and a safe exit.

- Check weather close to the event. Move inside or cancel outdoor sleeping if temperatures, rain, wind, or air quality are unsafe.

- No open flames, forced exposure, unsafe sleeping locations, simulated evictions, or withholding food, water, medication, or rest.

- Designate emergency contacts and a quiet indoor space.

Youth and privacy - Follow the host organization’s youth-protection rules, required screening, adult-to-youth supervision,

and parent/guardian permission.

- Young children should attend with a responsible guardian; overnight arrangements for minors require specific safeguarding plans.

- Never identify a participant as unhoused or invite public disclosure of a family’s housing status.

- Photography or recording requires permission, especially for minors and guest speakers.

Emotional safety and dignity - No "pretend you are homeless" role-playing or exercises designed to frighten or shame participants.

- Allow participants to pass on any question or activity. Avoid graphic trauma stories with younger children.

- Invite and compensate lived-experience speakers where possible; honor their boundaries and right to decline questions.

Always: If weather or site conditions make outdoor sleeping unsafe, hold an indoor program instead. Safety is not the lesson; understanding is.

04 - SAMPLE SCHEDULE

A simple program any group can host Use this as a flexible agenda. A school or youth club can stop after the evening reflection.

6:00 pm Welcome & purpose. Explain why the event exists and its limits.

6:15 pm Shared values. What makes a community safe, welcoming, and supportive?

6:30 pm Guest voice. First-person account or consented recording, with time for respectful questions.

7:00 pm Age-specific learning activity. Choose from the companion sheets.

7:45 pm Discussion. What did we assume? What did we learn? What remains hard?

8:15 pm Optional service. Sort preapproved supplies or connect participants to direct local support.

8:30 pm Closing reflection. Daytime/evening participants may depart.

Later Host-approved overnight. Only if permitted, supervised, and safe.

Morning 15-minute debrief. What was temporary for us? What is ongoing for others?

Facilitator opening: "Tonight is not a test of hardship, and it cannot recreate being homeless. We’re here to listen, learn, and understand some of the barriers our neighbors face ... and how we can respond with respect."

05 - ACTIVITY MENU

Learning by age ... choose your track These are original activities prepared for Chico Campout for Compassion, informed by established education programs. Full directions and printable worksheets appear in the separate activity sheets.

Ages 6 - 10 | "What makes a home?" 20 - 25 minutes. Draw or list what helps someone feel safe and cared for: warmth, privacy, a place to sleep, clean clothes, friends, and the ability to keep belongings. Talk about ways neighbors show kindness without judging anyone.

Ages 11 - 13 | "Everyday needs map" 30 - 35 minutes. Compare a typical day with the difficulty of reliably accessing ordinary needs: toilets, charging a phone, transportation, school supplies, a place to store things, and sleep. Build a community-support map.

Ages 14 - 17 | "A decision with no easy answer" 35 - 45 minutes. Examine fictional, non-graphic situations involving rent, work schedules, shelter rules, belongings, and school. Identify barriers and practical changes rather than blaming characters for constrained choices.

Adults / mixed ages | "Three perspectives, one neighborhood" 40 - 50 minutes. Discuss a resident concerned about public spaces, a neighbor without housing, and a service worker. Separate observations from assumptions and list goals they might share. Then consider what local actions are practical.

Any age | "Listen and reflect" A guest with lived experience, a verified first-person video, or a reading chosen with permission. Follow with a short discussion using the reflection prompts.

For every age group: never pressure anyone to disclose their own housing circumstances. A participant in the room may be experiencing homelessness now.

06 - GUEST SPEAKERS

How to host a first-person conversation People experiencing or formerly experiencing homelessness should help shape the event. Their knowledge is not a decoration for an activity.

Before the event - Explain the audience’s ages, setting, intended purpose, format, time limit, and any questions proposed.

- Let guests decide what topics are off limits; ask whether they prefer an interview, conversation, or prepared remarks.

- Offer an honorarium, travel reimbursement, or another arrangement the speaker considers fair where possible.

- Agree in advance about photos, livestreaming, audio recording, press, and later reuse; consent can be withheld.

- Ask whether the host can provide a quiet waiting area, an accessible entrance, and a support person if desired.

Good questions to ask - "What do you wish people understood better about being without stable housing?"

- "What ordinary task became unexpectedly difficult?"

- "What kinds of help made a real difference?"

- "What is one thing people should stop assuming?"

- "What would you like Chico to do differently?"

Do not ask - For details of trauma, addiction, arrests, abuse, diagnoses, or family separation unless the speaker

independently chooses that topic.

- "What did you do wrong?" or questions implying homelessness is an individual moral failure.

- A speaker to represent everyone who has experienced homelessness.

Source for deeper preparation: The National Health Care for the Homeless Council’s Social Storytelling Toolkit emphasizes trauma-informed stories and informed consent.

https://nhchc.org/media/storykit/ https://nhchc.org/media/storykit/

07 - DISCUSSION GUIDANCE

Dialogue that finds common ground The goal is not to make everyone adopt the same position. It is to hear legitimate concerns, correct harmful generalizations, and identify what neighbors could do together.

Try these questions - "What makes you feel safe and welcome in Chico?"

- "What changes would help both housed and unhoused neighbors?"

- "What is the difference between moving an encampment and helping someone obtain housing?"

- "What barriers make it hard to accept a shelter offer or hold a job?"

- "What might we be overlooking because we only see one part of the problem?"

Useful conversation agreements - Speak about people as individuals. No name-calling, jokes at someone’s expense, or sweeping labels.

- Use "I" statements and questions. Distinguish what you saw from what you inferred.

- Safety, housing, treatment, neighborhood conditions, costs, and dignity may all matter; participants may disagree on the solutions.

- Nobody is required to debate their own lived experience.

If a discussion gets heated: "We might disagree about the solution. What outcome are we both hoping for ... and what could help us tell whether it’s working?"

Grounding in the Invisible People toolkit The 2025 messaging toolkit explains that people may respond to the same housing solution for different reasons, including community wellbeing, safety, and responsible use of resources. This guide adapts that insight for listening and education ... not for teaching demographic stereotypes or running a persuasion workshop.

08 - DIRECT SUPPORT

Optional basic-needs drive ... no central fund The awareness program itself does not collect money or administer a shared fund. Participation is free, and giving is entirely optional.

Simple direct-donation model - Each host asks one existing Chico-area service organization what supplies are useful right now.

- The receiving organization approves a short list and a delivery location/time.

- Participants bring only approved items; sort safely and respectfully.

- The host delivers items directly to that organization and confirms receipt.

- Those who want to donate money do so directly to the nonprofit, not to Campout for Compassion.

Possible items ... only if requested New socks, basic hygiene items, unopened shelf-stable food, seasonal clothing, menstrual supplies, or other items named by the partner. Do not assume that every program wants the same supplies or accepts used items.

Good partners to approach Local shelters, outreach teams, housing organizations, youth service providers, food pantries, and other existing programs. Contact them before putting their name or logo on materials.

Keep the emphasis right: A bag of supplies may be helpful, but it is not a replacement for stable housing. This event is about understanding homelessness and valuing our neighbors.

09 - ACTION STEPS

A four-week host planning checklist October 18 - 24 | Commit

- Name one coordinator; choose evening-only or overnight.

- Seek venue approval and check local requirements.

- Choose your age groups and select activity sheets.

- Invite a lived-experience partner early, with consent and fair arrangements.

October 25 - 31 | Prepare

- Recruit adult helpers and follow youth-safety policies.

- Confirm accessible toilets, weather options, first aid, emergencies, and reasonable accommodations.

- Select materials; ask local partners about optional supplies.

November 1 - 7 | Confirm

- Confirm venue, permission, speaker, and participant instructions.

- Make sure families have consent and supervision information.

- Set a weather decision point and accessible indoor alternative.

November 8 - 14 | Host

- Monitor weather and issue final logistics; do not wait until the last minute to change the format.

- Brief volunteers and facilitators.

- Host the learning program; finish with reflection, not a hardship contest.

November 15 - 21 | Follow through

- Thank guests and helpers; deliver any approved donated goods.

- Share anonymized participation totals and learning feedback, not private stories.

- Discuss what future actions or conversations the group wishes to pursue.

10 - OUTREACH TEMPLATE

Copy-and-send invitation to a group Subject: Invitation ... Chico Campout for Compassion, November 14

Hello,

I’m inviting community groups, churches, schools, youth organizations, families, and neighbors to participate in Chico Campout for Compassion 2026 on Saturday, November 14.

The idea is simple ... one night, many locations, one community. Each participating organization can host its own safe, supervised gathering to learn about the realities of homelessness, listen to people with lived experience, and reflect on how we treat our neighbors.

Groups can participate through an evening program or an approved overnight campout. We’ll provide age-appropriate educational activities and a simple host guide.

This is not a fundraising campaign. An optional basic-needs drive can support existing local programs directly.

Would your group be interested in participating or helping develop the event?

Thank you, Scotty Franzyshen scotty@sfranzyshen.org

Suggested announcement (short) "Join Chico Campout for Compassion on Saturday, November 14 ... a communitywide night of learning and solidarity with neighbors experiencing homelessness. Groups host their own safe, supervised gatherings. No central fundraiser ... just awareness, listening, and compassion."

11 - FILL IN / KEEP A COPY

Host registration and event plan Group / family name:

_____

Lead contact: _____

Email / phone: _____

Location (private / approved public facility): _____

Type: [ ] Evening only [ ] Overnight [ ] Family [ ] Service partner

Age groups: [ ] 6 - 10 [ ] 11 - 13 [ ] 14 - 17 [ ] Adults / mixed

Expected participants: _____ Named safety lead: _____

Named youth safeguarding lead (if applicable): _____

Property permission confirmed: [ ] Yes [ ] No Insurance/permit review: [ ] Done

Accessible restroom / water: [ ] Yes Weather alternative: [ ] Confirmed

Guest speaker invitation / permission: _____

Local program for optional direct donations: _____

Chosen learning sheets: _____

Important accessibility or contingency notes:

Working date: November 14, 2026. This registration worksheet does not certify a venue, authorize minors to participate, or provide a public event permit.

12 - RESOURCE NOTES

Where these ideas come from These are references for organizers, not assignments for community participants. The Chico materials are an original adaptation, not an Invisible People or Covenant House product.

Invisible People ... Effective Homelessness Advocacy Messaging Toolkit (2025) Used as a messaging reference: respectful language, listening across differences, community values, public safety, support, and housing. Particularly useful sections: pp. 4, 6 - 7, 10, 14 - 15, 25 - 28, 30 - 34. Read the toolkit.

Covenant House ... Sleep Out Model for a shared evening, first-person learning, and morning reflection. Covenant House explicitly says its Sleep Out does not replicate homelessness. Its official events include fundraising, while this Chico event does not. Sleep Out FAQs.

Learning to Give ... homelessness lessons by grade Educator activities on respectful language, daily needs, preconceptions, and service for grades K - 12. The handouts here are newly written for Chico; they are not reproductions of that curriculum. Explore lessons.

SchoolHouse Connection ... awareness resources Resources about hidden family and student homelessness, educational supports, and plain-language awareness materials. Browse resources.

National Health Care for the Homeless Council ... storytelling Practical guidance on trauma-informed storytelling, consent, and releases. Storytelling resources.

Editorial note: General claims from education and messaging resources are not automatically Chico-specific statistics. If a host uses local numbers, confirm their date, population, and source first.

https://invisiblepeople.tv/2025research/invisible-people-messaging-toolkit/ https://www.sleepout.org/faqs https://www.sleepout.org/faqs https://www.learningtogive.org/resources/lessons-units?search_api_views_fulltext_1=Homelessness https://schoolhouseconnection.org/article/awareness-resources https://nhchc.org/media/storykit/

Optional video discussion resources

You can now choose from a curated collection of OrgCode and Invisible People videos for older youth and adult groups, including respectful language, youth and family housing, shelter choices, neighborhood concerns, and responses to encampments. The video guide offers age suggestions, discussion prompts, and viewing precautions. Younger children can use the existing hands-on activities without any video.

Open the Campout video discussion guide

Back to Campout for Compassion

Online edition: www.sfranzyshen.org/campout/resources/host-guide/

Questions? scotty@sfranzyshen.org